

phones, half-filled Styrofoam coffee containers, hundreds of unopened foil packs of ketchup and plastic envelopes of soy sauce, empty soda cans, coils of insulated wire, Plexiglas boxes resembling hamster cages, stacks of note pads—and, standing largely unused near the exit, huge garbage cans and a couple of push brooms.

Wherever you went, you'd run into big metal pipes and girders bristling with odd-size video-display screens and terminals—our “data banks.” The screens ranged in size from a six-inch personal-size monitor to the kind of tote boards found in most high-school or college gymnasiums. The first impression of a visiting friend of mine was, “Gee, just like the TV display wall at Sears!” There were so many video monitors stacked seemingly willy-nilly that, unless you were looking down from the balcony that runs along the side of the main AMEX trading room, it was impossible to see what was going on inside the pit. I suppose it could be argued that the Exchange's governors wanted it that way, but that presupposes they'd actually hired a space designer.

Actually, the pit *evolved* from a glamorized trading post and, like kudzu vine, ran amuck, consuming more and more real estate as XMI volume shot up. Changes came about through necessity. In the beginning the pit was littered with twenty or so fruit crates and cardboard boxes, courtesy of Greenwich Gourmet Deli, on which short traders and clerks used to stand in order to read broker badge numbers when it came time to record the trades. Built to transport fruit across the country, these boxes could not sustain the weight of people jumping up and down and so usually didn't last the day. It could be embarrassing for the clerks to stand atop a box, signal frantically, and find themselves suddenly sinking from sight as, one after another, the boxes collapsed. That sight must also have offended the governors' sense of decorum, as one morning a space-design consultant showed up with a clipboard to ask us all sorts of questions on our work habits. Not long afterward, the cardboard boxes disappeared. In their place, the house carpenters built and installed a num-